omnivores but live in an environment where fruit is plentiful most of the time. They forage in groups, and tend to use sex (including both hetero-and homosexual behaviours) to relieve tensions in social situations. Conflict is rare in bonobo societies, which are also matriarchal, unlike the male-dominated chimp communities.

An experiment carried out by researchers at Duke University, North Carolina, in 2017 showed that bonobos are also altruistic. Two bonobos (unknown to each other) were put in adjacent rooms (A and B) with a fence between them and a piece of fruit hanging over one room (B). The bonobo in room A could release the fruit but not get to it himself. The researchers found that this bonobo would consistently release the fruit, so that the other one could reach it, helping a stranger, with no reward for himself.

Researchers also observed how the sight of an unknown bonobo yawning in a film would trigger a yawning response in bonobos watching the film, suggesting a capacity for empathy. Other studies have shown how bonobos comfort each other when in distress. Unlike the “negative” behavior that humans share with chimps, these traits mirror more laudable human characteristics, such as compassion. Understanding such behavior in bonobos could shed light on how our human social behavior developed.